



Angkor Wat

A masterpiece of Khmer art and architecture, and the world's largest religious structure

The temple of Angkor Wat (meaning “city temple”) in Siem Reap, northwestern Cambodia, is the largest and one of the most impressive archaeological sites in the world, covering an area of some 0.6 square miles (1.6 square km). The temple was at the heart of a large, sprawling city, its parts linked by a network of roads and canals. Construction of the site began during the reign of King Suryavarman II (1113–c.1150), under the mighty Khmer Empire, which at the time ruled over much of mainland Southeast Asia. Vast sums were spent on glorifying the country's rulers by means of lavish building projects—none so awe-inspiring and ambitious as that of Angkor Wat.

An astonishing example of Khmer art and craftsmanship, the temple was conceived as a place of worship and protection and an endorsement of the king's authority and his claim to political

office. It is dedicated to the great Hindu god Vishnu, the preserver who protects and sustains the world, and with whom Suryavarman II identified himself specifically.

Depiction of myths

The temple features 13,000 square ft (1,200 square m) of exquisitely carved bas-reliefs, including the visual narration of eight major stories in Hindu myth. The highlight of these is generally thought to be the depiction of the Churning of the Ocean of Milk on the east gallery of the temple. The magnificent carving shows gods and demons churning the ocean to extract *soma*, the elixir of immortality.

Angkor Wat went into decline in the 14th century and was sacked by a Thai army in 1431. It was listed as a World Heritage Site in 1992.

The **construction** of the **temple** is thought to have involved around **300,000 workers**



△ CHURNING THE OCEAN OF MILK

This image shows a detail from one of Angkor Wat's most spectacular wall carvings. It depicts the Hindu creation myth, the Churning of the Ocean of Milk.

◁ TEMPLE COMPLEX

The central tower of the temple complex rises to a height of 213 ft (65 m) and is flanked by four smaller towers and a series of enclosure walls, which have corners at angles of precisely 90 degrees.

A SACRED MICROCOSM

Angkor Wat conforms to the Hindu concept of a sacred microcosm. Its five spectacular towers symbolize the peaks of mythical Mount Meru—the dwelling place of the gods for both Hindus and Buddhists—and its enormous moat (now dry), more than 590 ft (180 m) wide, represents the cosmic ocean that was thought to encircle Mount Meru.

